

LETTERS FROM BOOK REVIEW READERS

The New Volume of the Prose and Poetry of Robert Southey and Other Communications on Literary Topics of the Day

The New York Times Review of Books:
THE NEW YORK TIMES REVIEW OF BOOKS, commenting on a recently published volume of the "Select Prose of Robert Southey," and the fact that his poetry was fitted to stimulate the minds of his contemporaries, and that a surprising amount of research as shown in his prose, deserved the immortality due a conscientious student of science and philosophy, asks, "In the first years of the twentieth century who knows Southey?" This recalls the remark of a critic in the latter half of the last century that "few have written so much and so well as Southey and have been so little read." Macaulay wrote of his poems: "We doubt greatly if they will be read fifty years hence, but if they are read that they will be admired we have no doubt whatever." The poet himself said that he wrote to "obtain the approbation of that fit audience that, being contented that it should be few, I was sure to find." An English critic has said: "We shall not find in the poet laureate the creative imagination of Tennyson or Browning. . . . He soars to no heights of lyric rapture." His was not the power to unbear us to the high places from "the chains of care that to lower earth enthrall us."

There the wings of Freedom to inherit,
There to commune with a loftier spirit,
Where the enduring, and the winged are met.

In addition to the Riverside edition of his poems, there is a low-priced edition kept in stock by all the large booksellers, which leads us to believe that he still holds a place with a limited number of students.

Unlike too many of his confrères, Southey's personal life was altogether admirable. He bore uncomplainingly the burden of supporting certain unworthy people. He had excellent staying qualities as a friend. "Personal attachment first," he wrote, "and family circumstances later, connected me with Mr. Coleridge, and three and thirty years have ratified a friendship with Mr. Wordsworth, which we believe will not terminate with this life"; he gave a home for a long time to Coleridge.

I have found much pleasure in Southey as a word painter, and I make a few extracts from "Thalaba," an Arabian tale, for the enjoyment of Book Review readers. Cardinal Newman was much impressed with "Thalaba." "The versification," he said, "is most melodious, and many will not perceive they are reading blank verse." Southey's own explanation of its rhythm furnishes excellent advice to modern experimenters with vers libre; he attempted, he says, "the sense of harmony," "like the tone that every poet necessarily gives to poetry."

MOONLIGHT.
How beautiful is night!
A dewy freshness fills the silent air;
No mist obscures, nor cloud, nor speck, nor stain,
Breaks the serene of heaven;
In full orb'd glory yonder Moon divine
Rolls thro' the dark blue depth,
Beneath her steady ray
The desert-circle spreads,
Like the round ocean girdled with the sky.
How beautiful is night!

THE PALACE OF SHADAD.
Here emerald columns o'er the marble courts
Shed their green rays, as when amid a shower
The sun shines loveliest on the vernal corn.
Here Shadad bade the sapphire floor be laid,
As tho' with feet divine
To tread on azure light,
Like the blue pavement of the firmament.
Here, self-suspended hangs in air
As its pure substance loathed material touch,
The living carbuncle
Sun of the lofty dome,
— an ever-flowing spring
Of radiance like the day flood at its best.
The prophet Houd he brought;
And o'er the marble courts,
And o'er the gorgeous rooms
Glittering with gems and gold,
He led the man of God,
"Hast thou a fault to find
In all thine eyes have seen?"
With unadmonished pride the King exclaimed.
"Yea," said the man of God,
"The walls are weak, the building ill secure.
Azrael can enter in!
The Sarsar can pierce through,
The icy Wind of Death."

THE ETERNAL FIRE.
In the heart of earth it lives and glows
Her vital heat, till, at the day decreed,
The voice of God shall let its billows loose.
To deluge o'er with no abating flood
Our consummated World;
Which must, from that day in Infinity
Thro endless ages roll,
A penal orb of Fire.

THE WINTER STORM.
Now sank the evening sun,
A broad and beamless orb,
Adown the glowing sky:

Thro the red light the snowflakes fell like fire,
Louder grows the biting wind
And it drifts the dust of the snow. -
The snow is clotted in his hair,
The breath of Thalaba
Is iced upon his lips.
He looks around; the darkness,
The dizzy floating of the feathery sky
Close in his narrow view.

THE LOCUST.
— a Locust fell.
It fell upon the Maiden's robe,
And feebly there it stood, recovering slow,
The admiring girl surveyed
The outspread sails of green;
His gauzy underwings,
One closely to the grass-green body furled,
One ruffled in the fall, and half unclosed.
She viewed his jet-orbed eyes,
His glossy gorget bright,
Green glittering in the sun.
His plummy pliant horns,
That nearer as she gazed,
Bent tremblingly before her breath.

THE SEA ANEMONE.
Meanwhile with fuller reach and stronger swell,
Wave after wave advanced.
The living flower that, rooted to the rock,
Late from the thinner element
Shrank down within its purple stem to sleep,
Now feels the water, and again
Awakening, blossoms out
All its green anther necks.

I have wondered why the airship has not
appealed to the imagination of our modern
poets, but with the exception of a few lines
by Alfred Noyes, I do not know that anything
has been written worthy of the theme. It is
interesting to note, that Southey has de-
scribed with poetic vision a Ship of Heaven
in the Curse of Kehma.

Lo! at Ereenia's voice
A Ship of Heaven came sailing down the skies.
"Where wouldst thou bear her?" cries the an-
cient sire of gods.
"Straight to my bower of bliss," the Glendoe-
ver replies,
"To Indra's own abodes."
Then in the Ship of Heaven Ereenia laid
The waking, wondering Maid:
The winds that, loitering lagged along their
course,
Around the living bark enamoured play,
Swell underneath the sail and sing along its
way.
Smooth as the swan, when not a breeze at even
Disturbs the surface of the silver stream,
Thro' air and sunshine sails the Ship of
Heaven.
Recumbent there, the Maiden glides along
On her aerial way
How swift she feels not, tho', the swiftest
wind
Had flagged in flight behind.
Motionless, as a sleeping babe she lay,
And all serene in mind.
Feeling no fear; for that ethereal air
With such new life and joyance filled her
heart.
Fear could not enter there.
Thro' air and sunshine sails the Ship of
Heaven;
Far, far beneath them lies
The gross and heavy atmosphere of earth:
And with the Swerga gales
The Maid of mortal birth
At every breath a new delight inhales.
And now, toward its port, the Ship of
Heaven,
Swift as a falling meteor shapes its flight,
Yet gently as the dew of night, that gem,
But do not bend, the harebell's slenderest
stem.
"Daughter of earth,"
Ereenia cried, "alight;
This is thy place of rest, the Swerga this,
Lo, here my bower of bliss."
New York, April 20. V. T. ARTZ.